ATHENS ALIVE

USER RESEARCH

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OBJECTIVES

1. **Understand the needs & priorities of local events directors**: Identify the biggest challenges directors face when planning and operating events, particularly where the collective can provide support, resources, and a unified voice.

2. **Identify what features users need on the website**: Learn what directors, sponsors, government stakeholders, and community members need from the website and what would make it more useful, accessible, and engaging.

3. I**dentify what would be more appealing to potential sponsors**: Learn what organizations would want to see before financially supporting the Collective, including potential benefits, visibility, community impact, and partnership opportunities.

4. **Gather feedback to inform the Collective's new brand identity**: Understand how different audiences perceive the Collective and identify the qualities, values, and personality the branding should communicate.

RESEARCH STRATEGIES

Everyone we spoke to during the duration of compiling user research was carefully chosen, along with the type of interview we chose. Each person was chosen to reflect one of our target audiences, which allowed us to gather more specific and targeted research.

SURVEY:

Our survey was sent to both UGA students and Athens locals to understand how people in the communtiy currently perceive local events and the role they play in Athens. Their responses helped us identify what attracts people to events, how they discover them, and what they value most about the local event scene.

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS:

We also spoke directly with a few local event directors to gain insight into the challenges and needs of the people who plan and manage events in Athens. Their perspectives helped us understand how the Collective can better support event organizers, create opportunities for collaboration, and advocate for the local events community. We conducted an interview with a couple UGA students, as well, to gain a more personal perspective on the local event experience. This conversation helped us better understand how students discover events, what encourages them to attend, and what they would like to see from the Collective and it's website.

SECONDARY RESEARCH:

In addition to get primary research from the survey & interviews, we researched existing information about Athens' local event scene, including event organizations, community resources, government involvement, and sponsorship materials from other, similar organizations. This helped us better understand the current landscape, identify gaps and opportunities, and provide more context for our recommendations.

SURVEY

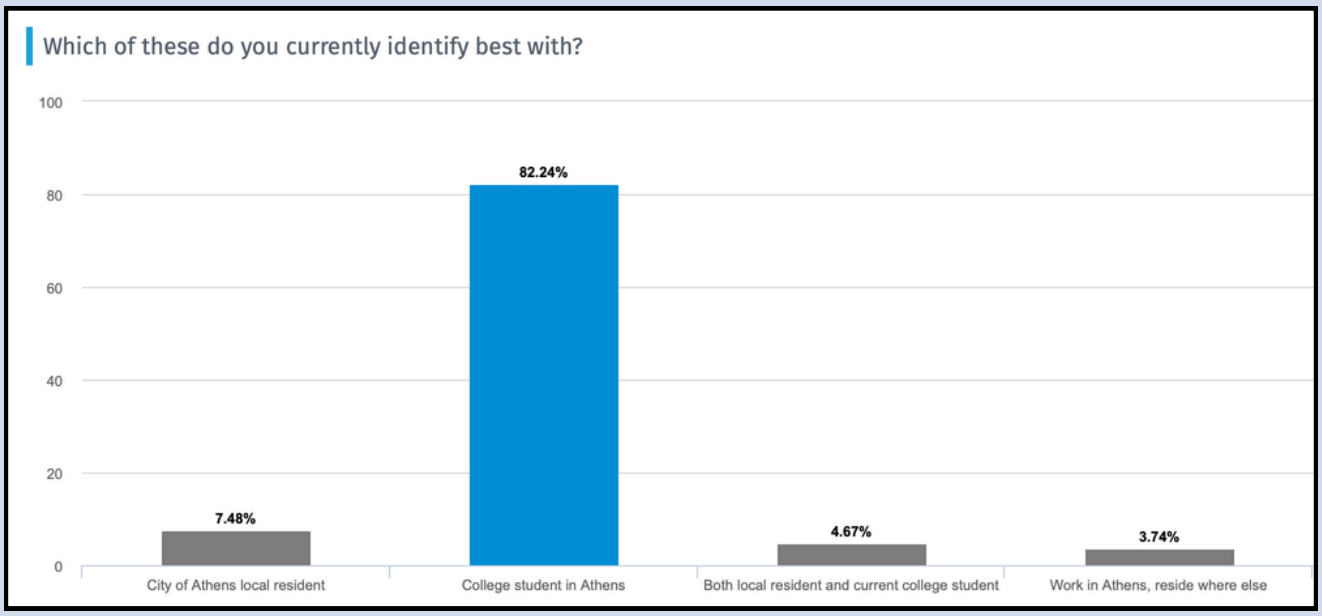
SURVEY DETAILS

WHAT OUR SURVEY LOOKS LIKE

- Distributed an anonymous, 9-question survey to **UGA students** and **Athens residents** from September 20th - September 28th
- Assessed festival interest, event knowledge and reach, perception on Athens, along with demographics (relation to city, years resided)
- Gathered **108 responses**
- Used insights to further inform our deliverables

KEY DEMOGRAPHICS

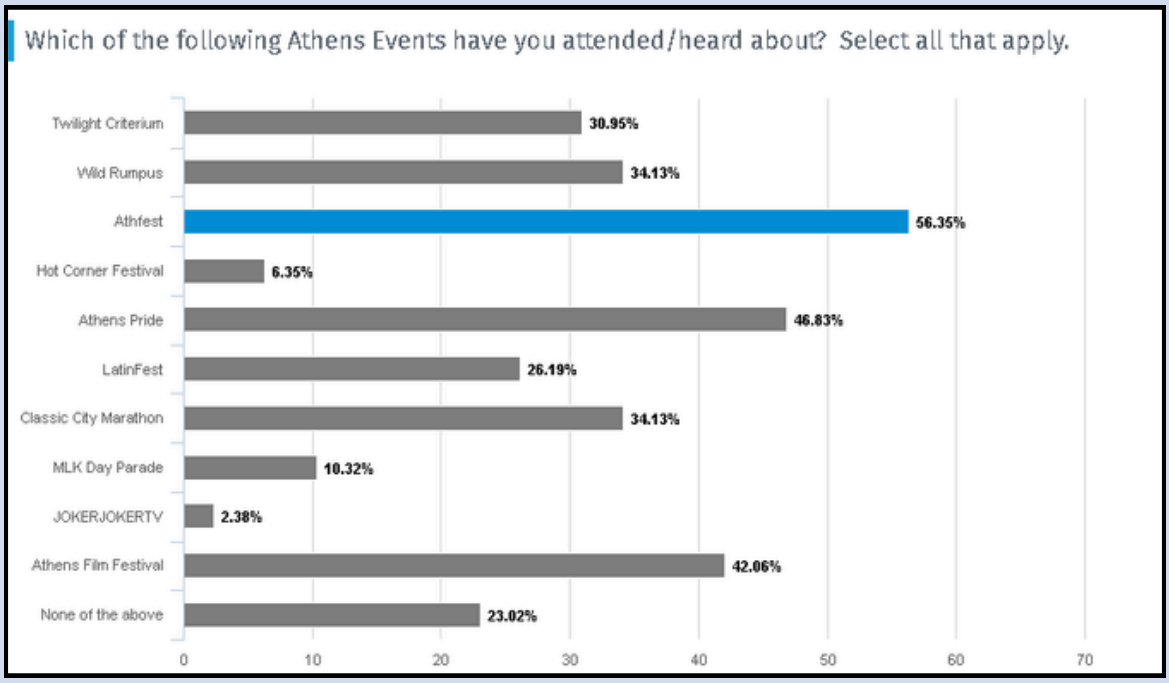
- 82.24% of respondents (n = 88) were college students; 4.67% (n = 5) were both students and local Athens residents.
- Almost half of respondents (n = 53) had temporarily or permanently resided in Athens for 1-3 years.



SURVEY ANALYSIS

QUESTION 1 TAKEAWAYS

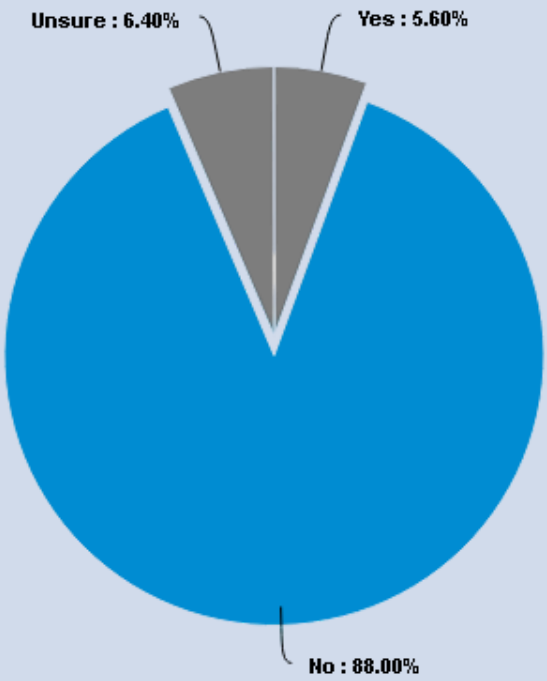
For every event, there was at least one respondent that had prior knowledge of the event. 23.02% of participants were unaware of any of the events under the Collective.



QUESTION 2 TAKEAWAYS

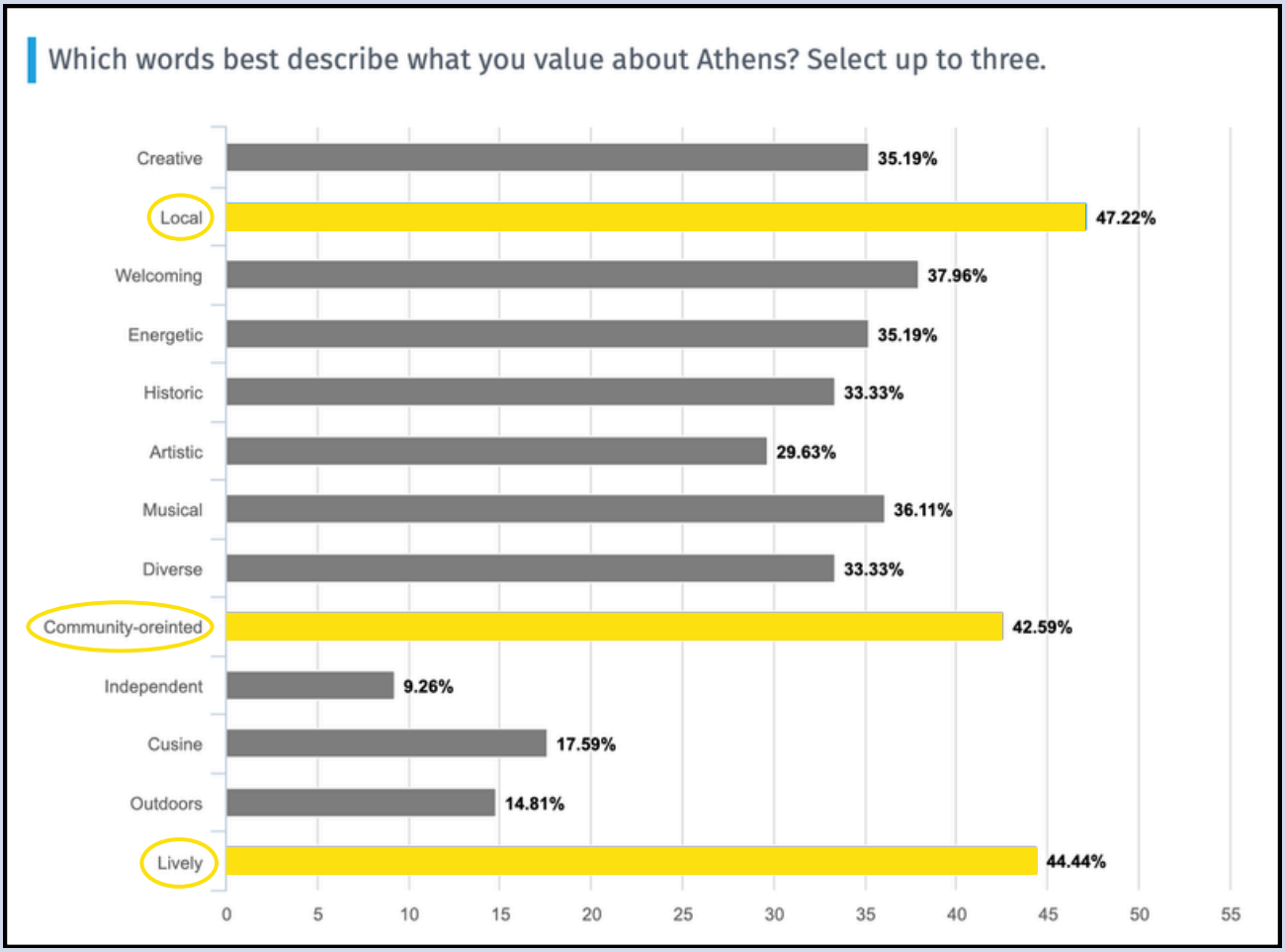
Before this survey, have you heard of the Athens Special Events Collective?

A significant majority of respondents did not confidently know of the Events Collective (n = 101). It is visible that, even though many respondents had heard of individual events, they did not know the collective as a whole.



SURVEY ANALYSIS

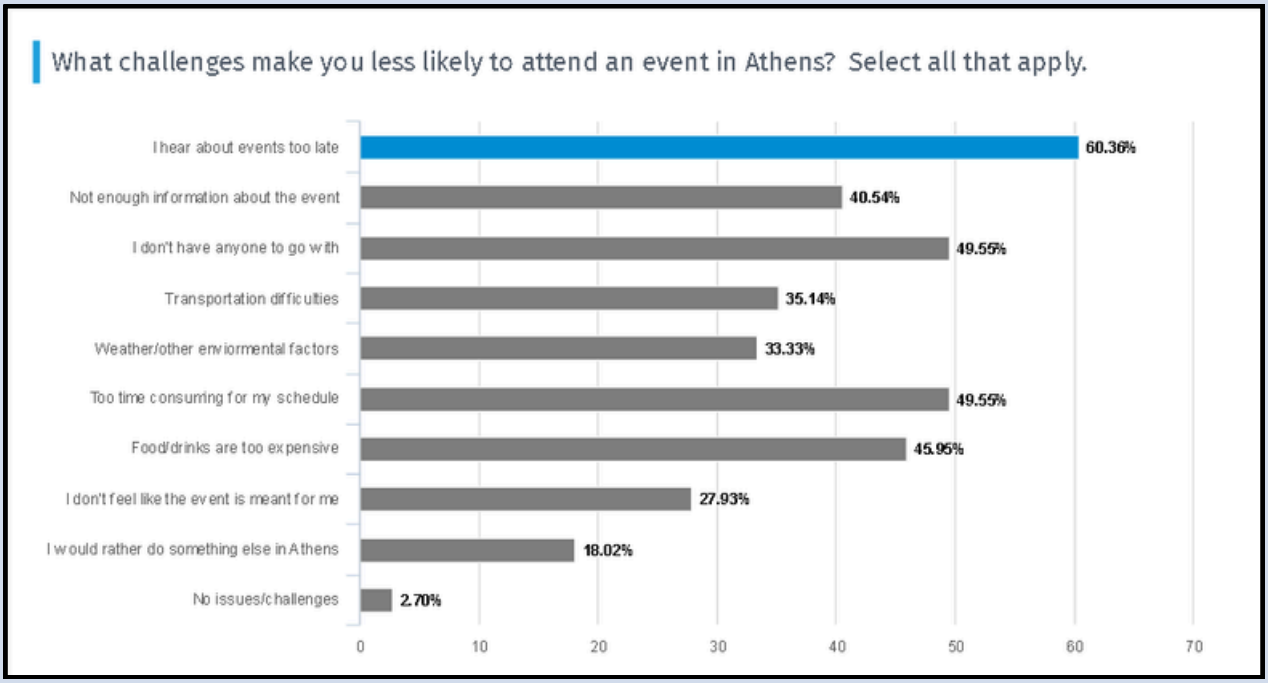
QUESTION 8 TAKEAWAYS



We asked respondents to pick out of 13 choices which 3 words best signified Athens. Many of our word choices yielded similar percentages between the 25-35% range, with a few distinctly lower.

3 specific words stood out to respondents; **Local**, at 47.22%, **Lively**, at 44.44%, and **Community-oriented**, at 42.59%. Analyzing our data, these are key phrases that - since many Athens residents and college students associated it with the city - we want to strongly reflect in our overally branding and deliverables moving forward.

SURVEY ANALYSIS



QUESTION 6 TAKEAWAYS

Only 3 respondents stated that they had no issues or challenges, while the rest had at least one problem they had faced. The biggest challenge respondents faced was **hearing about events too late** at 60.36%. It can be interpreted that part of the challenge may be a lack of advertisement, which can be attributed to a larger need for a cohesive image.

MAIN TAKEAWAYS

- Many individual events are known, but respondents have not heard of the Special Events Collective as a whole.
- Athens events vary in how well consumers know them, possibly being attributed to a variety of different individual communities. The collective should represent a celebration of diversity.
- There are many different words to describe Athens, but Local, Lively, and Community-oriented are the strongest descriptors.

INTERVIEWS

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS:

1. Can you tell us a little about the event that you represent and your role in organizing the event?
2. What are some of the biggest challenges you face when planning and promoting your event?
3. What did your numbers look like for the last event, and did you wish you had more people come?
4. What resources or support do you wish you had access to as an event director?
5. What do you think local event directors need the most from a Collective like this?
6. Where do you think there are gaps or opportunities for improvement?
7. How could the Collective better demonstrate its impact to the Athens community?
8. What do you think would make the Collective more appealing to potential sponsors?
9. What was the original goal of the website & branding when it was created?
10. Who do you envision as the primary audience for the website & brand?
11. What do you think is missing from the current website?
12. What features would be the most useful to event directors to include?
13. Are there any words, visuals, or ideas that you think should be associated with the Collective? Any that should not be associated?

INTERVIEW FINDINGS



(Photo/My Global Presence PR)

Chuck Griffin

Executive Director of Athens Film Festival

MAIN TAKEAWAYS

- Biggest challenge when planning & promoting the Athens Film Festival is getting exposure to different parts of the community
- Attendance at the film festival was up 30% last year, but he's ambitious and said, "I don't allow myself to be happy. Why can't we get more?"
- As event directors, they have a lot of resources like interns & volunteers, but as they grow, festivals require more resources like stage management, sound, etc.
- Hopes that as they grow, a bigger budget & tech resources could be offered for free
- Mentioned that a more cohesive brand & storytelling elements would make the Collective more compelling, meaning more people following the events & more sponsorships
- Currently, he believes there is a gap in the clarity of the messaging
- Believes that gathering data & presenting it in a way that's easy to read, including videos, photos, etc., would make the Collective more appealing
- Mentioned that the website & overall brand needs a new logo, more media showing different festivals, events page, & public support page

INTERVIEW FINDINGS



(Photo/Online Athens)

Mary Joyce

Executive Director of AthFest

MAIN TAKEAWAYS

- Said that volunteer recruitment was very difficult when planning the event each year; mentioned that a volunteer option on the website could be helpful for all events
- Brought up the fact that sponsorships have gone down in past years for each event because of economic uncertainty
- Mentioned an interest in a shared inventory between events (ex: barricades can be used between events); eventually add this to the website
- Stated that having clearer views on what they want the Collective to do could better demonstrate impact
- Wasn't aware of the want to expand more externally; believed the Collective was only there to internally help the directors
- Believes that having an internal "Directors" login for the website could help internal communication between directors

CLIENT MEETING FINDINGS

Gene Dixon

Director of Athens Twilight



(Photo/Groundbridge)

Timi Conley

Executive Director of Wild Rumpus



(Photo/Wild Rumpus)

MAIN TAKEAWAYS

- For the brand guidelines, they both said to think about the longevity of the color palettes, name, etc. (don’t just follow what's trendy)
- Wants the sponsorship deck centered on what the Collective can deliver & mention the different audiences for the various events
- Want to focus the sponsorship deck on finding a sponsor for the Collective; smaller events would benefit from this more, since sponsorship money can be spread over multiple events
- Mentioned that they feel like Athens is losing it’s culture to corporate brands, and they want to preserve the uniqueness of the city

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

STUDENT INTERVIEW:

1. How often do you go to events or activities around Athens that are NOT associated with UGA?
2. Think about the last event you went to in Athens. What was it, and how did you hear about it?
3. How often do you come acress events that you didn't know were happening?
4. What information do you usually look for before deciding whether to go to an event?
5. Have you ever wanted to attend an event but decided against it? If so, what happened?
6. What makes you want to return to an event?
7. Do you think it's easy or difficult for UGA students to find things to do outside of campus? Why is that?
8. What would make you actually use an app or website for discovering Athens events?
9. What features would be useful when deciding on which event to attend?
10. What information do current event listings usually leave out that you wish you knew?
11. What's one problem you've personally experienced when trying to find or attend something in Athens?

Interview Findings



(Photo/Online Athens)

Arya Brown

UGA Alumni

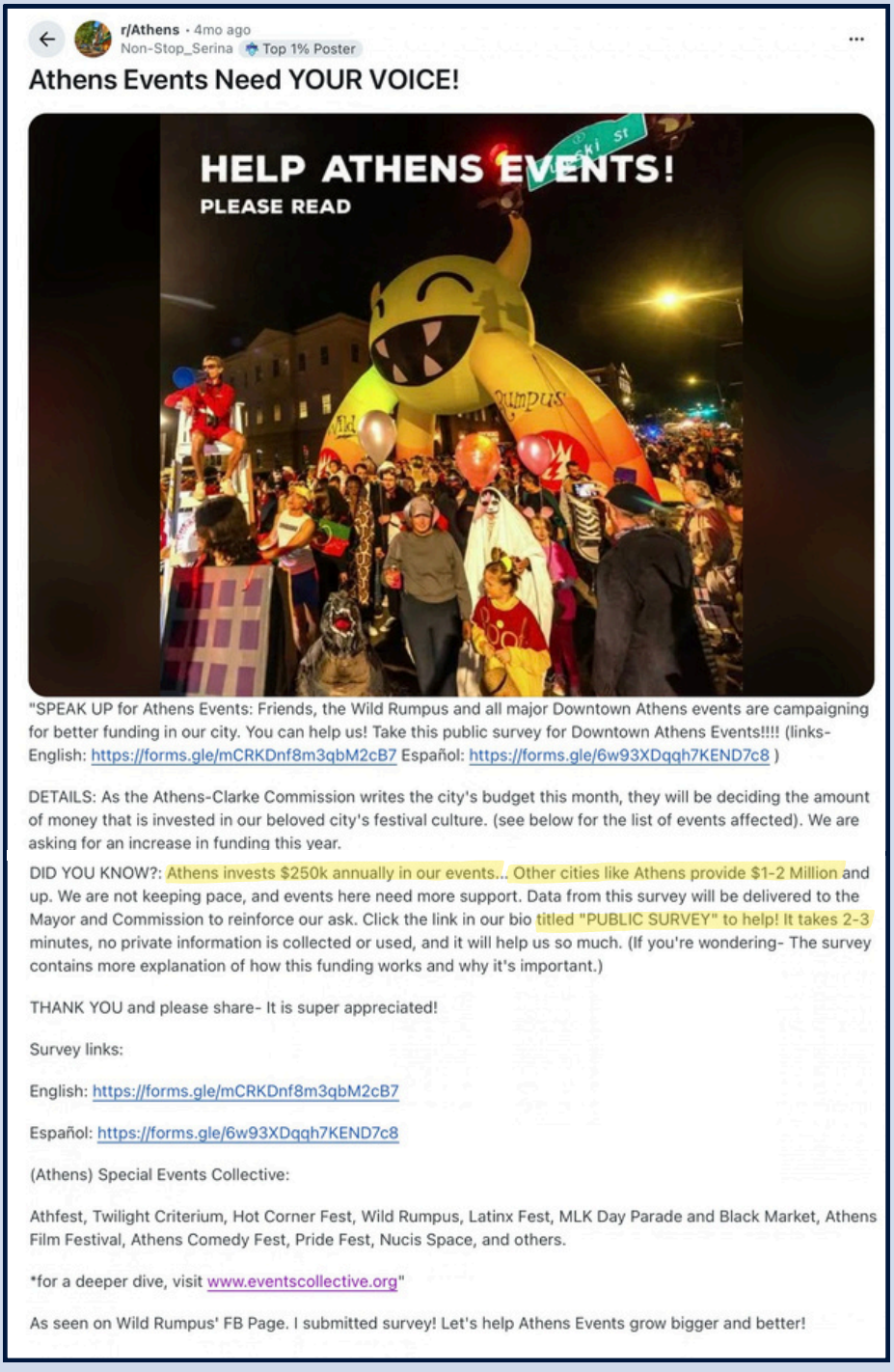
MAIN TAKEAWAYS

- Mentioned she would be more likely to go to an event if it had free food or activities
- Only Athens events she heard about were AthFest and Wild Rumpus, since she went to Wild Rumpus last year through word of mouth
- Often found herself sending events around Athens to her friends from Instagram, but they would never go through with plans due to lack of information from the initial post
- Knows that there are a lot of different events around Athens, but it's hard to actually learn about each of the events
- If there's a seasonal event around a holiday (like Halloween for Wild Rumpus), she would be more likely to go again saying, "I feel like I am in the festive spirit, so it's always fun to find events that celebrate certain times of the year."

SECONDARY RESEARCH

REDDIT THREAD

When researching the Collective online, we found very few resources. What we did come across was an Instagram post about the Collective's formation posted by Timi Conley, Director of Wild Rumpus, and a Reddit post about the Collective posted 4 months ago. The Reddit post can be seen below:



r/Athens · 4mo ago
Non-Stop_Serina Top 1% Poster

Athens Events Need YOUR VOICE!

"SPEAK UP for Athens Events: Friends, the Wild Rumpus and all major Downtown Athens events are campaigning for better funding in our city. You can help us! Take this public survey for Downtown Athens Events!!!! (links- English: https://forms.gle/mCRKDnf8m3qbM2cB7 Español: https://forms.gle/6w93XDqqh7KEND7c8)

DETAILS: As the Athens-Clarke Commission writes the city's budget this month, they will be deciding the amount of money that is invested in our beloved city's festival culture. (see below for the list of events affected). We are asking for an increase in funding this year.

DID YOU KNOW?: Athens invests $250k annually in our events... Other cities like Athens provide $1-2 Million and up. We are not keeping pace, and events here need more support. Data from this survey will be delivered to the Mayor and Commission to reinforce our ask. Click the link in our bio titled "PUBLIC SURVEY" to help! It takes 2-3 minutes, no private information is collected or used, and it will help us so much. (If you're wondering- The survey contains more explanation of how this funding works and why it's important.)

THANK YOU and please share- It is super appreciated!

Survey links:

English: https://forms.gle/mCRKDnf8m3qbM2cB7

Español: https://forms.gle/6w93XDqqh7KEND7c8

(Athens) Special Events Collective:

Athfest, Twilight Criterium, Hot Corner Fest, Wild Rumpus, Latinx Fest, MLK Day Parade and Black Market, Athens Film Festival, Athens Comedy Fest, Pride Fest, Nucis Space, and others.

*for a deeper dive, visit www.eventscollective.org"

As seen on Wild Rumpus' FB Page. I submitted survey! Let's help Athens Events grow bigger and better!

REDDIT THREAD

The Reddit post includes information about what the Collective wants to achieve. It tells readers that Athens invests $250,000 annually in the events, but other comparable cities provide $1-2 million or more for their events.

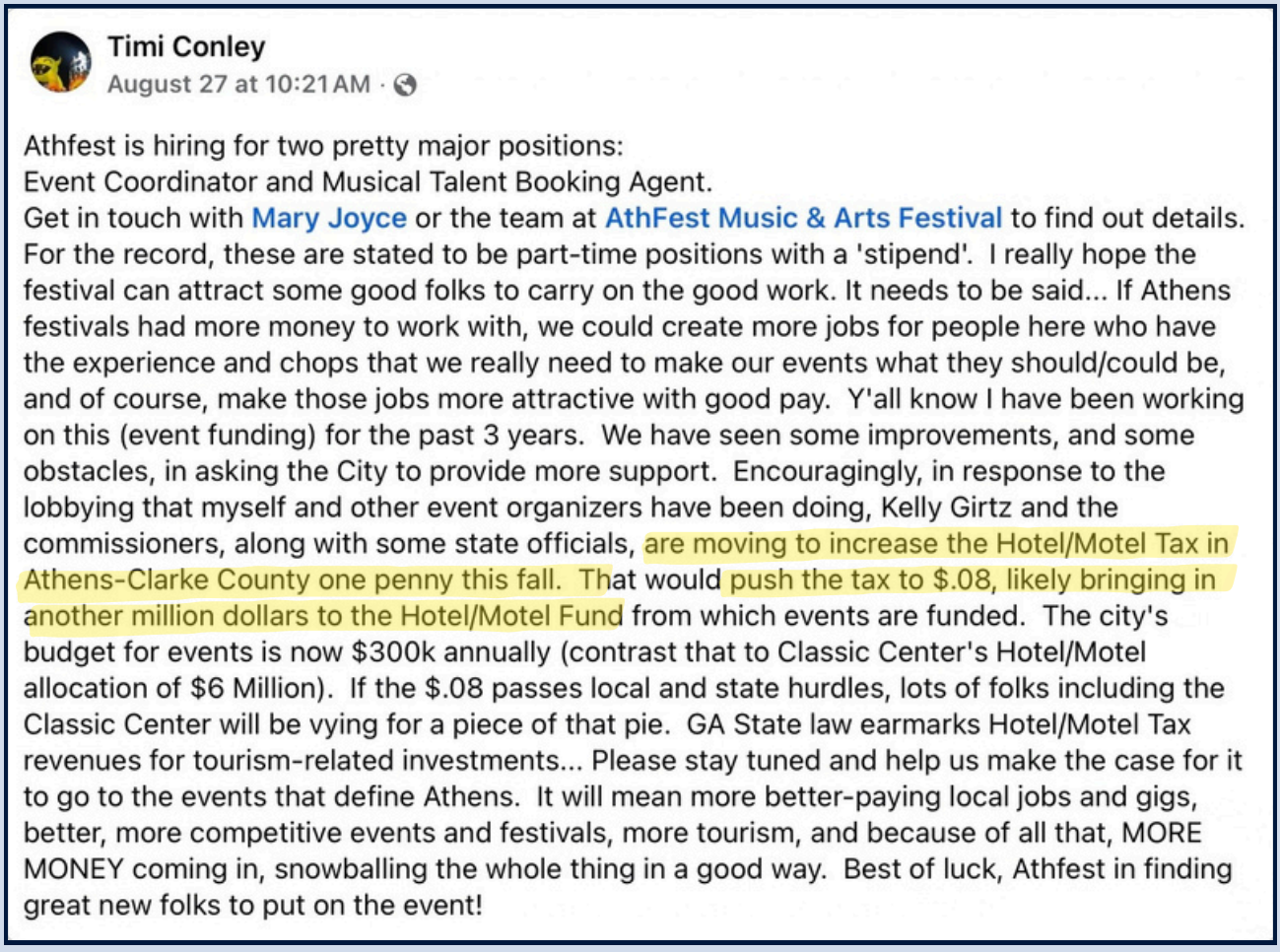
They attached a survey, much like ours, and the data from the survey was sent to the Mayor and Commission to support their ask for more funding.

The survey can be found HERE and comments from supporters on the Reddit post can be seen below. The comments showed us that there is a need for sponsorships through the Collective, rather than each event, because more events will benefit.



FACEBOOK POST

We also found a Facebook post from Timi Conley from August. He talks about how the Collective is moving to increase the Hotel/Motel Tax in Athens, by $.08 which will hopefully bring in another million dollars per year for local events.



Timi Conley
August 27 at 10:21 AM ·

Athfest is hiring for two pretty major positions:
Event Coordinator and Musical Talent Booking Agent.
Get in touch with Mary Joyce or the team at AthFest Music & Arts Festival to find out details.
For the record, these are stated to be part-time positions with a 'stipend'. I really hope the festival can attract some good folks to carry on the good work. It needs to be said... If Athens festivals had more money to work with, we could create more jobs for people here who have the experience and chops that we really need to make our events what they should/could be, and of course, make those jobs more attractive with good pay. Y'all know I have been working on this (event funding) for the past 3 years. We have seen some improvements, and some obstacles, in asking the City to provide more support. Encouragingly, in response to the lobbying that myself and other event organizers have been doing, Kelly Girtz and the commissioners, along with some state officials, are moving to increase the Hotel/Motel Tax in Athens-Clarke County one penny this fall. That would push the tax to $.08, likely bringing in another million dollars to the Hotel/Motel Fund from which events are funded. The city's budget for events is now $300k annually (contrast that to Classic Center's Hotel/Motel allocation of $6 Million). If the $.08 passes local and state hurdles, lots of folks including the Classic Center will be vying for a piece of that pie. GA State law earmarks Hotel/Motel Tax revenues for tourism-related investments... Please stay tuned and help us make the case for it to go to the events that define Athens. It will mean more better-paying local jobs and gigs, better, more competitive events and festivals, more tourism, and because of all that, MORE MONEY coming in, snowballing the whole thing in a good way. Best of luck, Athfest in finding great new folks to put on the event!

This helps us understand more about what the Collective is working towards with local government. Our long-term goal for the semester is to create materials for them to use when talking with local government, along with sponsorship materials. We now know how that money will be allocated, which influences how we will craft these materials.

FLAGPOLE ARTICLE

Blake Aued, a writer at Flagpole in Athens, wrote an article in June of 2025 discussing how much money Athens-Clarke County puts into local events each year. He mentions that the Collective is hoping for more money each year. The article can be read HERE. This gives us more insight into how the Hotel/Motel tax, which pays for the events in Athens, is allocated.



CATEGORIES | CITY DOPE | NEWS

Should ACC Spend More Money on Events Like AthFest?

Musician Timi Conley asked the mayor and commission for more funding for events like the Halloween parade he organizes, Wild Rumpus.

by Blake Aued June 25, 2025

"Most of that revenue [from the Hotel/Motel tax] currently goes to the Classic Center."

"Conley said...special events deserve a larger share of ACC's 7% hotel/motel tax, which brought in $5.8 million last year."